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LITERARY MAGAZINE

SAXIFRAGE

VOLUME 48

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SPRING

**SAXIFRAGE
LITERARY
MAGAZINE**



VOLUME 48



SAXIFRAGE LITERARY MAGAZINE

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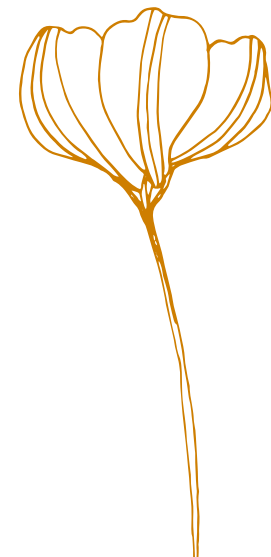
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Saxifrage Volume 48

Pacific Lutheran University rests on the traditional land of the Nisqually, Puyallup, Squaxin Island, and Steilacoom peoples. We are grateful to make art, and acknowledge the natural caretakers of this land.

Saxifrage is an annual anthology featuring the work of students, faculty, staff, and alumni from Pacific Lutheran University. All submissions were judged anonymously by the editors and a group of student volunteers.

Saxifrage was designed in Adobe InDesign 2020, set in Helvetica and Bebas Neue, and printed by Girlie Press Inc.



This school year offered us the opportunity to return Saxifrage to print, a change us editors and collaborators are grateful to offer. As with everything, the pandemic created a set of challenges, as we worked primarily remotely and digitally over 2020 and 2021. Through gracious patience and creativity, we were able to publish several online editions of the magazine, allowing Saxifrage to persevere through these difficult times.

Saxifrage 48 includes a wide variety of both writing and visual art. This edition showcases some of the talent the community at Pacific Lutheran University has to offer, and we hope that you will find passion through theirs. We thank you for your contributions and for all of those who supported this issue.

Your Saxifrage Editors

Ally, Casey, Danielle, Emily, Lisa

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LOOSE ENDS

Marlee Lawson

Throughout my life, I've had many family members tell me how much I would have loved my Grandpa Rog. Although he passed away when I was little, so I can't remember how his voice sounded and have to be reminded of what he looked like through old pictures, I've always felt extremely connected to him. I remember finding his collections of art journals on a bookshelf in my house, and as soon as I started to flip through the first notebook titled "Loose Ends," an old journal with slightly yellowed pages and a worn red cover, I immediately fell in love with the variety of art styles it contained. On one page, he would sketch ordinary objects with simplistic, consistent line work, but then on the next page, it's something drastically different, like an imaginative, whimsical creature. The notebook was also filled with memories and scenery from trips, or a funny moment as a comic that made you feel like you were there laughing with him. Each page is a surprise, with contrasting, mixed matched designs, and at times with grocery lists or song lyrics ideas scattered throughout. I love the jumble of ideas, patterns, memories, dreams, and techniques on each page. It reminds me of what my mind is like when I get a burst of creative energy, filled with collections of diverse ideas that I can't seem to keep up with, leaving several "loose ends." I've heard many artists preaching to spend time finding your own, unique style, and how important it is to stick to that niche, but I've never wanted to do that. Seeing my grandpa's artwork proved that. I want my art to be a collage and collection of emotions, images, and feelings, that differ stylistically depending on the day, even the hour that they are created.

After coming across a very simplistic sketch of a cluttered desk, crowded with plants in various jars, I felt compelled to recreate it. My intent was not to try and finish what he started, instead to grow the connection I felt to him in the only way I knew how. Just like how I don't know what the actual colors of these plants or pots were, I don't know what was going on in his life or what compelled him to make this sketch. So, I just lightly drew the basic shapes and filled it in with what felt right, not overthinking it. After losing track of time, I looked down at my completed watercolor and was surprised at how naturally the tones and shading came to me. Later I showed my dad both the original drawing his father sketched and my recreation, and I got to discover even more of the meaning behind these drawings. He told me that his dad would often make sketches like the one I used and let him and his brother paint them in, like a custom coloring book. This was just another occurrence that made me realize despite there being so much I don't know about my grandpa, I recognize we shared a similar creative mindset, sentimentality, and a need to write ideas and images down in hopes of not leaving "loose ends".

LOOSE ENDS (CONTINUED)

Marlee Lawson



Roger Lawson 1976



Marlee Lawson 2021

LISTEN

Malia Wisham

The woods are silent. The stars run across.

Is my life so boring?

Sphinxlike dream of forests with
dark pools of water racing to the finish.

Wishing I was wardrobelike,
deep enough to combat worries.
A foggy frog in hypertonic solution,
shriveling away in disguise
waterlogged from overcompensation.

A Bladeless Sword with no fight
like dancing water lilies and lemon pies
listlessly lying on the beach.

Work ache for pain killers.

I am conflicted.

The frigid dark forest ringing with incandescent
light at the end of its starless tunnel
where the huckleberry brush huffily surrounds snow huskies.

Encompassed by a restful glow,
curled in a fluffy white blanket
as bleach suffocated the bathroom,
He stood with abs cramped hands raised
the whipped cream mountain,
white stiff peaks
smothered in pink sauce,
sweet.

Make color part of your message

When wood paneled red, brown, white barns

Fade as sunlight strips its color to blush
like lost love dimming over time.

MOM

Mila Fuentes

I think this is the worst birthday present you can ever get. One of the worst, at least. Having your parents be deported might be worse. Definitely. At least I have my dad, and a house, and food. I'm very lucky, really. But I don't need my dad as much as my mom. Not that I would be okay if he died, I wouldn't. And not that I want him to be sick in my mom's place, I don't. But there's a key difference there. Because if my dad died, I would be completely distraught and need therapy for years, but if my mom died, I'd want to kill myself. I couldn't bear the world without her.

Pre-grief is weird. You get this warning that you have to be completely kind and loving in advance so that their last memory of you isn't you being an asshole. But you also run out of time to make up for the things you've already done. That's a big loss. Time. Maybe you are just an asshole. But you hope they know it doesn't mean you love them any less.

I turn 18 in two weeks. It was already bad enough that my senior year got canceled. Not that I like school, I don't, but I like learning. I don't like most of the people, but I like doing pre-calculus every day from 9:12 to 10:02, and seeing my mom at 11:48, telling her "I love you" when I go through the lunch line. Now my mom is 100 miles away getting chemicals pumped into her, all alone with no true human contact for the next month, no visitors allowed. She's never missed my birthday before, and now there's a chance that

she'll miss every single one for the rest of my life. I don't want to get married, but if for some reason I do, she'll never see it. I don't want to have kids, either, I'm too scared of passing down my shitty mental health genes. But I promised lady god that if my mom's blood doesn't kill her, I'll push one out. I don't think God cares if I have kids, though, but she's gotta love my mom. She has to.

Uncertainty is terrifying. Maybe it's better if the people you love just die, suddenly disappear. Because then you're not waiting for it. But you're not sure if it'll really come. Maybe you are sure, but you're scared to be. You're scared that if you even think that thought, their fate will be decided. If you truly believe it, it'll happen. So you keep waiting and waiting, and the uncertainty continues to eat away at you, suck you up like a black hole until you have no hope left. You're nothing, and you know that you're nothing because there's nothing you can do. You're helpless, hopeless, worthless, nothing.

Soon, the people who stood behind you, offered you support, know that it's coming, too. And the always ignorant messages of love and "I'm here for you; I know exactly how you feel" stop coming. You didn't think you would miss them, but you do. You do.

Here it comes.

A BRIEF LIST OF SOUNDS ONE MIGHT HEAR AND BE REMINDED OF LOVE

Anna Nguyen

the thud of grasshoppers falling into dry grass and leaves,
the cooing of pigeons as you sit at an unfamiliar bus stop,
babies laughing, obviously,
the decisive plink of a small, round stone tossed into water,
the sound of someone, somewhere, reciting Having a Coke with You to their lover,
as lovers do when they want to express an affinity for poetry
and thus by extension the other seductive romantic arts like
remembering how you like your laundry sorted and
making one-person tasks into two-person tasks, like
when you hold the dustpan and they hold the broom, and then
they say they love you and you tell them about
those cooing pigeons you saw at the bus stop, and how
reciting Having a Coke with You feels like second base, and how
maybe later you could go skip stones together and watch the sunset, and how
you've missed them, you've missed them,
you've missed them.

IN THE PALM OF MY HAND

Abigail Thompson

I feel my breath more keenly nowadays. My senses have narrowed like my eyes on a sunny day, focusing on *feeling*. Pure and simple.

My chest rises and falls: pulling air in, pushing it out. A constant that I convince myself has not changed. I hold onto that. I grasp at it with fingernails and white knuckles and bloody fingertips.

I was breathing then, I am breathing now. The only thing different is the ache in my chest, a child pulling on the edge of my shirt.

Look at me, she says.

Pay attention to me, she cries.

She points at pictures of years past, of places I visit in my dreams, of people I only see through texts and screens and she weeps, clutching my fingers like lifelines.

The sun slides across the sky and the cold wind caresses my face as I cradle her hand in my palms. I feel the sun wrapping around us, warm and inviting. Happiness is slow, but I know that it will join us in time.

Why do I ache? Why do I hurt so bad? She hiccups.

I don't have an answer for her. I haven't had one for a while. All I can do is hold her hand while her tears carve channels down my cheeks.

And I breathe. In and Out.

THE BEACH

Malia Wisham

There's a beach I take them to, when I tell them what happened. The water ebbs and flows with unpredictable emotion, it's the right setting. On a clear afternoon, my beach is just a 14-minute drive from the dorms. Long enough to think through exactly how I want to organize my words, and short enough that the drive home won't be too painful if I don't say it right.

When we get to the beach we sit on the driftwood bench, not yet dedicated, but still plagued. We sit on the driftwood bench and I tell them how he took me on the log, that the shirt he ripped off of me was white, that my jeans were from the Gap. That I begged him to go. That I bled. That I didn't fight back.

It's a necessary conversation.

It's a necessary conversation because they have to know. They have to know why I don't want them to sleep over yet, they have to know why on certain days I don't want them to kiss my neck. Because they will wonder. They will wonder why sometimes it clenches and I can't make it open up, and they can't fit in despite how desperately I want to give them pleasure. They have to know.

I don't look at them until I have finished saying what I rehearsed. They never look the same as they did before. Their faces have sunken, the color drained. I never remember what we say afterward, what they say. Often it's nothing at all, and we walk back to the car. They always lead the way.

After I tell them what happened, I discreetly pick up a rock. It's a memento, a token, proof that the conversation has been had. And if they don't stick around, if they can't bring themselves to stay, I take the rock back to the beach. Take it home to the water and re-integrate it with its ecosystem. Heal it.

I took him there on a Tuesday, the same day I was born. It was sunny, and there were young, beautiful families there who made it hard to find the right moment. But I found it. And I told him everything. And then I told him how my mother didn't believe me, and how when she finally did it was at the museum, and that that's why I have my tattoo. And I cried. And I breathed.

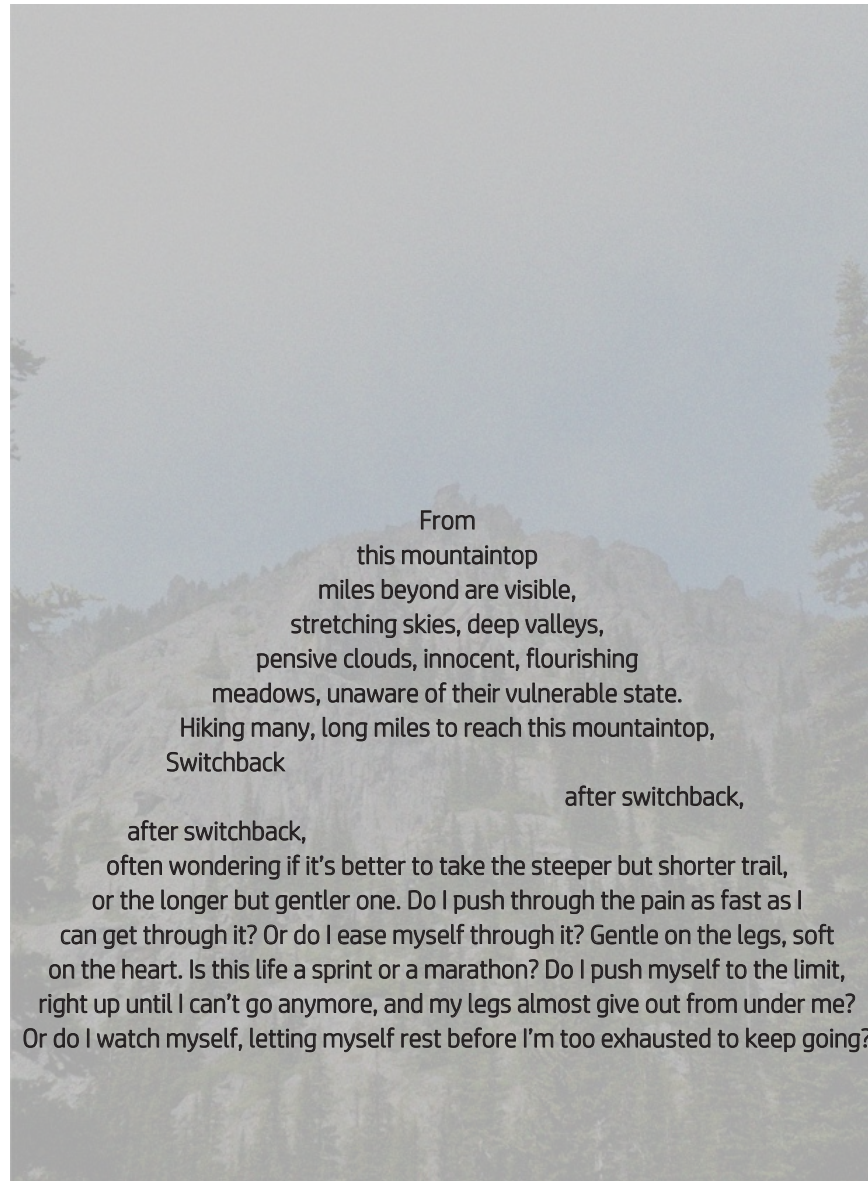
When I turned to look at his face, I found myself suddenly wrapped in his arms, my head buried warmly in his chest. He smelled like sandalwood and coffee. Safe. And I remember everything he said, as he softly stroked my hair. I remember how he told me that he was so proud of me, that I was so strong and brave for sharing it with him. That he felt honored that I did. And when I looked up, his cheeks were rosy with a gentle smile, and the sun was reflecting gold onto his skin. And as we walked back to the car, he held my hand and stroked my thumb with his.

His rock is speckled green, like his eyes. I keep it on my dashboard. I think it will stay there.

FROM THIS MOUNTAINTOP

Emily Toycen

Hybrid Work



LETTER TO MY MOTHER

Lisa Ha

Digital Painting

THERE IS BLUE INK IN MY MOUTH

Sage Warner

There is blue ink in my mouth
trying to burst from my lips,
staining them like the best lipstick.
Its midnight dyed
my tongue indigo and
my teeth are robin's eggs.

I want to spit it out.
It is thick and suffocating
too much like blood.
No one can see it.
It is my blood,
it is too much
of me.
It would be a Rorschach test
on the inside of my head.

Do you see the birds here?
Their wings are gummed up
hollow bones no longer hollow
filled in and weighed down
drowning in the ink.
I keep my mouth closed.





UNTITLED

Elizabeth Bankowski
Oil Painting

CREATIV MIND

Sarah Potwin
Acrylic on Acrylic Paper



Fifteen years ago, lapping waves
teemed with translucent jellyfish

Flapping white sails through the Budd Inlet
raced with the wind Decomposing crabs marked
the signature perfume of low tide under
speckled aquamarine skies

She caught your gaze from the deck's reflection,
anticipating the velocity of the jump But as you leapt,
betrothed to the boat, your body didn't leave
completely

Years later, you'll recall the chilled whitecaps
striking your chest, laughing at the predicament
Refusal to call an ambulance,
blood staining the steering wheel

The symphony of sawing bones,
unable to assemble the pieces
Numbness followed by
searing,
roaring nerves

CARNIVOROUS CONJUGAL CRABS

Abbie Hughes

Ashen, aggressive crabs danced in my premature
barnacle-torn hands We huddled on the slanted beach,
uneven rocks nipping at our ankles
Your eyes locked with mine as my mother
gagged at the sea breeze which raised her

A wee child I seemed to him and
graceless with a mind
So delicate a girl
Honeyvoiced and presenting as a façade,
you lied

Those are the creatures who stole your finger

MEMORY/CREATION

Rachel Mouer

Narrative Comic

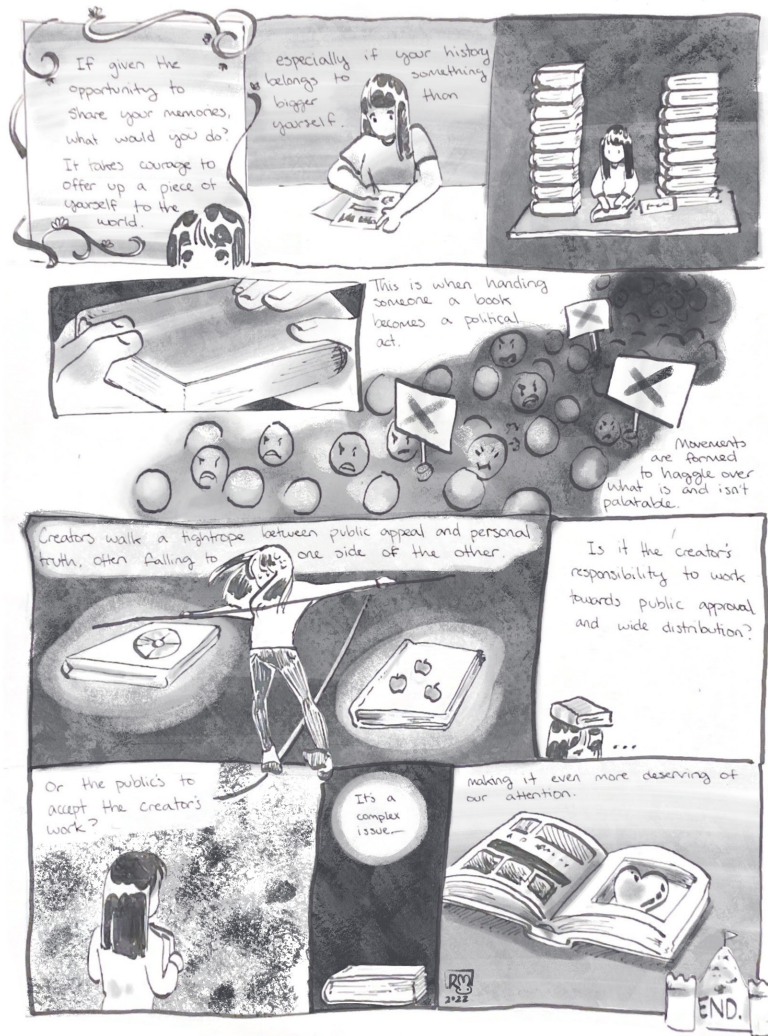


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MEMORY/CREATION (CONTINUED)

Rachel Mouer

Narrative Comic



PJ Sills

from

26

VACANCY

Abbie Hughes

You stroke their petite heads, poorly attempting to provide a sense of stability. The lenders look upon you with revulsion, shouting obscenities. The children never deserved this. Your fixed, regiment routine worked out well. Day in and day out, you gathered bread scraps and an occasional poppyseed muffin, cleaned their matted hair, and kissed them goodnight. The repetition kept you going, kept you alive. Four splintered walls. It wasn't much, but it was a nest. They never wanted you here, but you kept your family hidden. You just had to be caught. The sanctuary was no longer safe; it was being foreclosed.

Run. Struggling to gather your bearings, you take off. Dodge the broom. Avoid the freshly polished Alexander McQueens which engulf you as they pass. Ignore the singeing cayenne pepper ingrained into your backside. Disregard the twisted expression on the maid's face as you head her direction. Take a left. Scurry across the gritty hallway with piss-colored carpet. Out the side door, anchored by a cigarette case. Free at last. For now.

The dreary alley is illuminated by a single faded tangerine wall sconce. Accompanied by stacks of soggy Amazon packages left to soak in the rain and the putrid stench of vomit, you recognize the severity of the situation. A siren sounds in the distance. Your gut fills with unease, inducing nausea. Unfiltered air enters your lungs, tightening your throat. They quiver, looking to you for assurance. There is no protocol for this, no routine. How are you fit to be a mother if you can't shield your family from the dangers of the world? Everything will be okay. It won't. Oh, but it will. At least that's what you tell them. For you will never confess to

your consternation. Stay here. Hide. They wail as you leave, body bathing in the rainfall.

Scampering onto the craggy turf, a swarm of weathered tires threaten to euthanize you. Men sporting baggy discolored sweatshirts and acid-washed jeans that hang below their thighs shove graphic T-shirts into bystanders. Blinding billboards display a kaleidoscope of vibrant pixels. Bikers shout at pedestrians who shriek at taxi drivers who scream at the noise of it all. An overexposure of pandemonium terrorizes your senses. As hysteria hinders the mission, you struggle to maintain your concentration. There's no time for complications. Your children need you.

Nearing the sidewalk, the current pulls you off the curb toward imminent death. The jail bars await your arrival, ready to chomp on your extremities. As you enter the obsidian void, the rancid river swallows you whole. Sloshing and slashing until you can no longer combat the stream, you're washed onto a ragged bench. Although the sickening sewer almost drowned you, there is utter silence as it is hidden from the bustling city.

Following the steps up towards the manhole, you gleefully bolt towards the location of your children, ready to celebrate the news. However, as you return, the scene registers. You never should have left the comfort of your routine. Never should have been caught. Your mouth opens but no sound comes out. Choking on the taste of carrion. Paralyzed, unable to move away in disdain or forward to see their withered faces. A man with a watered-down blue tracksuit sweeps your sons and daughters into a rotting trash bag, maggots feasting upon their flesh.

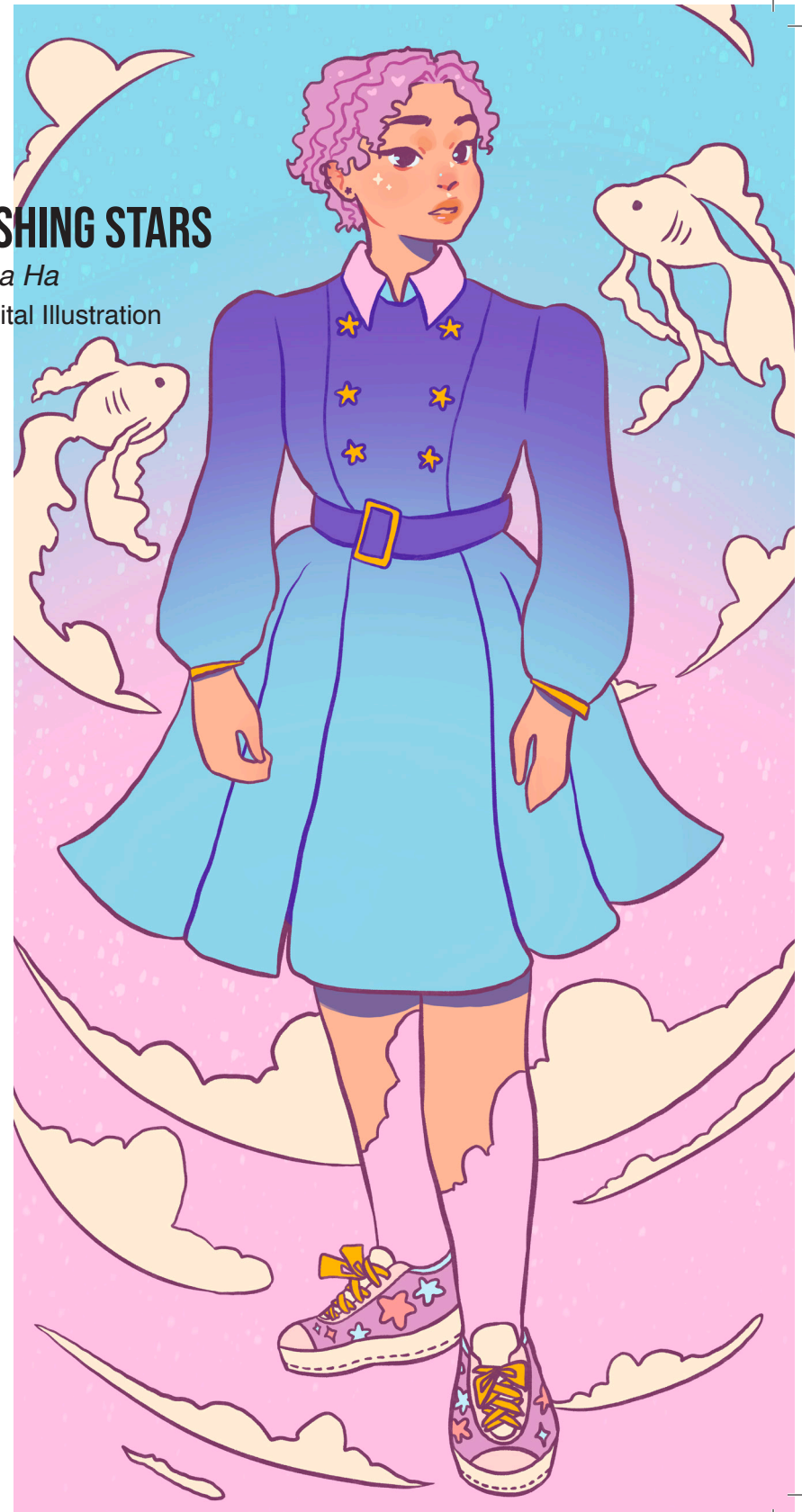
GLIDING

Sarah Potwin
Graphite



FISHING STARS

Lisa Ha
Digital Illustration



LESSONS ON MEMORY

Abbie Hughes

I was taught that moldy walnuts were like a faded memory,
worn and didn't belong in places they were meant to be.
Filling up buckets upon buckets with nowhere to go,
flies circle the wasted potential.
Entwined with pastel pills,
one of the same.
Miss a day,
take an extra helping.
And another.

Driving home late at night,
too late for her to be awake. She calls,
distressed.

Why did no one tell her that her husband died fifteen years ago?

Trapped,
her fifteen-year-old self banged at the door.
Let me go.
Let me go.

A scratched vinyl,
skipping to the chorus as if we hadn't heard it before.
Endlessly repeating
verse
after verse
until it tires.

Black and white lenses in a pop art world,
a contrast so vivid yet so bleak.
A concept so foreign yet so familiar,
so difficult yet so practiced.

The blaring alarm of jewelry advertisements,
the TV screen taking the role of sunlight.
A time lapse of commercials,
feet rooted to the ground.
Falling asleep in the La-Z-Boy recliner
with the same clothes from last week.

Fifteen trips to the bathroom in fifteen minutes.

Fifteen strangers enter her home over fifteen days.

I was taught to engage in one-sided conversations in a room
in a place filled with expired coupons and week-old Chinese takeout.
To shake hands that had been forgotten to be washed.
To smile but not how long to wait
until the gesture wasn't reciprocated.

WAKE

Nathan Lovitt

Glossy rectangles of varying sizes
spread out over the surface
of a rosewood table,

A collage of a life departed and its memories acting as
static plasticine eyes trapped permanently
in the moments they behold.

My mother has been fanning them out
along the table, pulling even more from leathery, dusty
books
curated across the lifetime of her sister, and

My mother's hair in the pictures a rich, bold brown, almost
black, now
hanging around her face bright and silvery like the medical
bracelet on her wrist,
and as she pulls more from their crackling plastic sleeves

A tear falls from her eye, capturing the image of the collage
in a bulbous reflection, descending in a single second yet
suspended
in each moment of freefall as if they were individual eterni-
ties,

Holding in stasis the sepia green of the rolling, grassy hills
of central North Dakota and the cracked pavement under
a corrugated baby blue carport.

Beneath, beside, and above the carport stands a girl, a wom-
an, my aunt
in her own separate frames in sundresses and ironed-out
church clothes,
at a time before the myriad of heart problems that would
leave her
sullen like the black-and-white portraits of her grandparents.

Inevitably the teardrop lands,
spreading itself over the image of a seagull
frozen in flight, rays of sunshine cutting
through the gaps in its feathers,

And for the eye that was once behind the camera
there is no concept of disease, pain, or death,
no heart surgeries or rushed rides to the hospital.
Not even the passage of time.

Instead she stays with the seagull
wreathed in the summer sun of 1978,
still alive, even now, in her own kind
of forever.

PARIS MAGIC

Stephanie Knaack

The day after her mom moved into her house, Spencer got up early to make tea and breakfast: black tea with lemon and scrambled eggs for her mom, peppermint tea and toast for herself. She slowly made her way upstairs to her guest bedroom, trying to reach it without spilling anything. As she raised her hand to knock, one slice of toast slid off her tray and fell onto the hardwood, butter-side down.

She sighed and decided to pick it up later, rather than bend down and risk spilling the rest of the tray, and rapped softly on the door. When there was no response after a few louder taps, Spencer twisted the knob and risked a peek inside.

The blinds were down, the curtains drawn, the room pitch-black. She could just barely tell that the shape under layers of blankets was her mother, Bobbi, fast asleep. As Spencer rapped on the side of the doorframe, the shape murmured something unintelligible and rolled over.

"Hey, mamma," Spencer strode across the room to the window, stopping along the way to set the tray down on the desk. She pulled the curtains apart and the blinds up, eliciting a groan from her mother as she came back to the land of the living.

"What time is it?" Bobbi mumbled, blinking and wiping the sleep from her eyes.

"It's just past eight." She responded, bringing the tray over to the bed and sitting down on the edge as her mother sat up.

"Why so early?" Bobbi groaned as she stretched her arms above her head.

"I woke up and couldn't get back to sleep. Besides, you said you've been sleeping all day, every day for the past few weeks." Spencer

handed her one of the steaming mugs. "I made you some tea."

"No coffee?"

Spencer shook her head. "I need to get some more at the store today."

"Rats." Bobbi took the mug and inhaled the scent before taking a sip.

"At least you still remember how I like it."

Spencer watched her mother's face change in the early morning light, from half-asleep and confused to a hardened sadness as she remembered everything. She took another sip of tea, gazing out the window at the sun rising over the quiet suburban street outside. It was a far cry from the cozy lakeside cabin she'd recently moved out of after being dumped by her now-ex fiancé.

"I'm really sorry things didn't work out with Reggie, mom." Spencer reached out to put her hand on top of Bobbi's, then changed her mind at the last moment and picked up her plate instead, taking a bite of buttered bread.

"Yeah, me too." Bobbi ran a hand over her graying hair and sighed, offering her daughter a half-hearted smile.

"You should eat something. Please?" Spencer gestured towards the eggs. "They're going to get cold."

"All right, I will. Just give me a minute." Bobbi took another sip of tea.

"How are you feeling today?"

"Jesus, Spence, I don't know. Can you give me a few minutes to wake up?" Bobbi snapped, slumping back against the pile of pillows behind her. She exhaled and closed her eyes for a moment, rubbing her temple in slow circles.

"I'm sorry. I can leave you alone for a bit, if you want." Spencer stood up. Maybe this had all been a mistake—not just breakfast, but inviting her mom to come stay with her in the first place. Their relationship had been strained for years now, ever since Spencer had left for college. She'd never had a rebellious phase as a teen, and she and Bobbi had been quite close back then—maybe even best friends. But college had opened up a rift between them, and it had been growing ever since. Spencer had seen this time as an opportunity to begin mending their bond, but it looked as though that would be a tougher task than she'd anticipated.

"No, I'm sorry." Bobbi said, muffled, her face in her hands. She sniffled, and Spencer brought her a tissue from the box on the dresser.

"It's okay, mom. I know you're going through it right now." Spencer said, hovering at the edge of the bed. She didn't know whether her mother actually wanted her to stay, or if she was just trying not to hurt her feelings.

"Yeah. You could say that." Bobbi cleared her throat, swiping at her eyes.

"You remember when I was fifteen and I got dumped for the first time?" Spencer started slowly. "I had to call you to come pick me up from school because I couldn't stop crying. And I cried for the whole car ride until we got home, and you made me a mug of tea with lemon juice and a ton of sugar, and it calmed me down enough to stop crying for a while."

"I remember." Bobbi nodded. "That tea was called Paris Magic. I still remember, because I haven't been able to find it anywhere since then. They must have discontinued it."

"Well, I thought...I mean, maybe it's stupid, but I thought maybe some tea would help you, like it helped me. You know?"

Bobbi managed a smile. "You've always been such a sweetheart. Thank you, Spence."

Spencer nodded. She picked up her own mug and plate, leaving the tray on the bed, and moved toward the door. "I'm gonna go clean up downstairs. Maybe we can get lunch later, if you're feeling up to it?"

"Okay." Bobbi nodded. Her eyes were misty and far-away, but she picked up her fork and had a bite of her eggs, so Spencer felt okay about leaving her alone. She shut the bedroom door behind her and nearly tripped over her cat, Wilson, who was nibbling at the edges of the toast she'd dropped earlier.

"Silly goose." Spencer tsked absently, picking the slice up between two fingers and dropping it in the trash once she got down to the kitchen. Instead of getting started on her work for the day, she found herself searching online for Paris Magic tea. It had been discontinued from all American stores, as far as she could see, so if she wanted to order some, it would have to be shipped overseas from France.

"What the hell, her birthday's coming up soon, anyways." Spencer muttered to herself as she confirmed her purchase. It would probably take at least a month to ship, but if it would cheer her mother up, it would be worth it.

She shut her laptop as she heard footsteps on the stairs and looked up to see her mother enter the kitchen a moment later. Bobbi was holding Wilson in her arms, tears streaming down her face. Wilson hated to be picked up, but he was tolerating it for the moment. Bobbi stroked his soft orange fur and let out a sob.

"Oh, mamma." Spencer stood and crossed to her mother, pulling her into a hug. "Do you want to talk about what happened?"

"Yeah." Bobbi sniffled, barely above a whisper.

"Okay." Spencer pulled away and picked out two more mugs. "Sit down, I'll make us some more tea."



EDITED 2

Milagros Garcia
Photograph

EDITED 1

Milagros Garcia
Photograph



A CONVERSATION WITH ARAM MRJOIAN: LIFE AS A WRITER

Danielle Pernell

Danielle: So you are a working writer, but also a professor. How do you balance the two?

Aram: It's difficult honestly, but I think I've kind of learned to treat every day like its own thing. I'm different from a lot of writers in that sense. I don't sit down and write every morning or every night. I have a lot of writer friends that are like, this is my morning routine, and this is my before bed routine, stuff like that. I tend to just write when it fits in with the rest of my schedule. Usually, that means that there's some structured time in the day, whether that's a half hour or an hour. I'd like it to be more than that but it's just not always the case. Like, if I'm teaching, teaching takes priority. I usually have things in different stages of publication so I need to respond to an editor or have different emails to get out. I might have copy edits for someone or other projects, sometimes the writing takes a backseat to all of that. Then there's just normal life things like walking the dog or date night. I think for a lot of writers, the routine is very important. But for me, having the flexibility to write when I want to write is kind of the way that I managed my time. It's one of the nice things about teaching. There are times that are very busy, but mostly it gives me some sense of flexibility.

The other thing I'll say, for people that want to be writers is, occasionally, just be really selfish. Sometimes be like, you know what, it's been a few days, I'm going to set everything else aside and write.

Danielle: Okay. So, your best advice for writers is to be a little selfish. Then for you, do you see it as being selfish or time management?

Aram: It's kind of both. For me, time management is huge. But eventually, there are moments where if I want to write, I have to think about what I'm going to have to sacrifice elsewhere. I guess, when I say being selfish as a writer, it's not only with my time, but also just with the reality that is writing. Like, if I'm writing nonfiction, sometimes I write things that aren't the nicest to other people. Or if I'm writing fiction, sometimes I'm attacking certain political or cultural ideas that I know are going to upset certain people. So sometimes the selfishness is in the subject matter. It's been difficult in the past, writing about certain stuff and then having to talk to family or friends or my wife about it, but there's kind of no other way to do it. And so I think it's kind of like a weird type of selfishness that also can be really communal. It starts out maybe from a place of needing to personally understand something, but then opens up a lot of conversations with other people as well.

Danielle: You brought up creative nonfiction (CNF) but I know you as a fiction writer. Is there a genre that you prefer to work within?

Aram: I love fiction and I love writing short stories. The novel that I've been working on for the last couple years has been so much fun, and I've just started another novel. I think of myself as a fiction writer, but I generally write CNF. I mean, it's easier for me to get those things published regularly and get paid for it. I think part of being a working writer is opening myself up to CNF and now it's become its own thing.

I have this almost addictive tendency to read a lot of CNF and I like writing a lot of hybrid criticism and craft essays now. But it's still kind of weird when someone says, "oh, you're a CNF writer". I always want to say "well, no, I'm a fiction writer that also writes CNF". I think they've kind of evened out, honestly.

Danielle: Thinking of you as a working writer, where was the transition from hobby to profession? Or was writing ever a hobby?

Aram: Writing in some ways still feels like a hobby. For me, and I say this all the time, writing is not what I make money off of. I make money from teaching and editorial projects. For a long time, the writing I was doing and was passionate about, I was getting paid nothing or very little for. I did write as a day job, but in a completely different capacity. I was working in content marketing, and public relations doing a lot of writing that was very corporate and boring. But that paid my bills, and allowed me to focus on other types of writing on the side. At some point I started getting better editorial gigs, and those paid more. I started getting better teaching gigs and that paid a little more. For fiction, I might make 100 bucks off a short story. The most I've ever made per piece of nonfiction is about 1000. I hope that grows and I can make more off of that. I've worked for Tri-quarterly for a long time and that paid me an annual stipend. And now as a professor, I get a salary to teach writing. You have to have something else that is sustaining you because very few people can afford, at least initially, to write for a living.

Danielle: Going back to your work that's been submitted to Tri-quarterly and The Rumpus, is there anything you would say stands out? What would you say is a defining aspect of your work?

Aram: You know, it's hard for me to think about that. In terms of my own work, what people have told me, particularly what editors that I've worked with, is that I'm good at taking difficult political or cultural subject matter and making it funny. Like being able to write with a mix of humor and honesty. I think that's always kind of been something that interests me. Like, I want to talk about big issues, but I struggle to write about anything super seriously. I kind of need to almost come at it with a joke, even if sometimes it's a little bit over the top. I love dad jokes. I love bad puns. I think those make writing fun. So I guess that's kind of become my stylistic marker. Just being able to think what's frustrating me. Is it gun

violence, historical erasure, or is it the environmental crisis? How am I going to come at that in a way that still kind of allows me to find some humor? Then, some positivity.

Danielle: Would you say that makes you more of a humor writer or a satirist?

Aram: No, I don't think so. I'm terrible at writing satire. Usually I try to come in through a speculative lens but I write some realism. The novel I just finished is, I would say, literary realism. But most of the short stories I'm writing are kind of speculative. They're kind of climate fiction, or maybe even sci-fi or slipstream. To me that's not necessarily satire. It's more looking at the world and thinking, what's some of the worst stuff I can imagine? But then trying to filter it with some elemental of hope.

Danielle: Would you say that that's your primary source of inspiration?

Aram: I think so. A lot of my early writing was exploring identity, which I know people have different feelings about. Some folks find it really problematic or reductive. But thinking about my Armenian identity was really interesting to me. And then more recently I've been thinking a lot about the environmental crisis. I'm constantly kind of on the edge about my own carbon footprint and the way our world is changing. We're at a turning point, you know. We ignored something for so long and now it's becoming unendurable. So yeah, I think for me, right now, the environment is really critical to my creative work. I think it probably will continue to be for some time.

Danielle: Does writing about more difficult topics ever feel draining for you? I can only imagine what constantly thinking and writing about impending doom does to you.

Aram: I feel weirdly like grief, whether that's like premature grief or past grief, has always kind of been a wellspring for my work. Same with this kind of anxiety. So it can be draining at times, but

it's almost better for me to look at it through the lens of writing than to just being sad about it. At least if I'm writing about it, I feel like I'm making sense of it in some way or doing something. It's not the same type of activism as going out and fixing the environmental problem, but I think it kind of awakens people to how my thinking works. I'm hoping that it has some type of collective effect. Literature can be used to be part of the solution.

Danielle: Well I wholeheartedly believe that writing and literature are its own forms of activism. Being in your classes, I've noticed that our work doesn't always go in that direction. Is that more of a choice on your part or is it more about introducing more diverse topics?

Aram: You know it's hard for me to look at young writers and want to push them in a particular direction. Something I saw too much in my own writing education was ideas like, this is what has literary merit, or this is how short fiction is supposed to work. I'm trying to push against that because I think the best artists find ways to make their own decisions. That involves looking at a lot of different stuff. So I guess, part of my counter argument would be, in a lot of the work I assign, you do see that element of activism, or you do see someone taking a really complex topic and trying to make it digestible or new and interesting. Part of it is showing students a wide range of content, and giving them a wide range of ways to approach their own artistic work. My belief is that down the line, they will use those tools however makes the most sense for them. Not everybody who writes wants to be an activist. Some people just want to write because it's therapeutic or it helps them grapple with trauma. Some people write because it's what they've been told they're good at, or because they see some vision of fame and fortune in the future which is becoming less and less realistic. There's a lot of different reasons to write and I don't want to force someone to see my reasoning.

Danielle: Does this mean that your reason for writing is to help make sense of the world?

Aram: It's always been that way. I wouldn't stop writing if I stopped teaching or editing. If it became where I needed to make money doing something else, whether that's selling insurance, or, I don't know, opening a pizzeria, I would continue to write because regardless of what I'm doing professionally, personally, I need to write because it's a way of taking all the complex stuff that's jumbled up in my head, organizing it, and putting it to good use.

Danielle: So if writing is a need, would you say that teaching is also a need? Or is it more of a calling?

Aram: I mean, it's hard to know. They're inspiring in different ways. Like I wouldn't trade teaching my students for anything. I think that particularly American education makes it difficult to be excited about teaching because there's not always a ton of opportunities. Right now, in higher ed, there's few jobs and you can't always choose where you're going to live. You don't necessarily get paid well and tenure opportunities are becoming fewer and fewer. I love teaching, I would stick with this forever if it made sense. But I've become less set on the idea that it's the only way to sustain my writing and enjoy this communal writing space. I used to think that teaching at the college level was something that would allow a certain type of writing lifestyle. I no longer think it does. There are plenty of other ways to be a working writer. People need day jobs and need to provide for themselves and their families. I'm very passionate about teaching and working with my students and seeing their growth. But I'm less married to it as a long term solution for my own professional growth. It just doesn't seem like the best space for writers to really be developing anymore. That's really a detriment to students in my mind, because I think students are losing a lot of really creative, innovative, and very caring educators because they can't afford to stay in this space.

Danielle: As a caring educator, what are some of the struggles that come with that?

Aram: Universities don't, in my mind, support their faculty or their students very well. I mean, universities have always been a business and that means that certain things fall by the wayside. It's not an accident that so many places are cutting the humanities. That's a detriment to students, and not just those in humanities. But all students who would probably take one or two literature classes if their course schedule allowed it. Having faculty that don't feel supported, not having the stability of tenure, to constantly be moving around and looking for a better situation, that causes burnout. I think the hard part about being a caring teacher right now, is that there's just not a system that really invests in that.

Danielle: I want to talk a little more about this idea of burn out. Is there burn out in teaching like there is in writing?

Aram: Absolutely, yeah. There are a lot of days where I just kind of wonder like why did I ever go get my PhD? Why did I continue on this path when I had a good job that paid me well and that I didn't have to think about outside the office? I don't have weekends the same way I used to anymore. If I haven't replied to a student's email or gotten grades back, that bothers me. It sticks in the back of my head all day. That can lead to burnout. There's always going to be a struggle to balance teaching and writing. I have to ask what's more important? Is it advancing my own career? Or is it benefiting my students and knowing that I have this long sustainable track to the personal and professional growth I want. It's a daily struggle, honestly. Something has to change, whether that's a different teaching situation or different writing situation. The part that worries me is that a lot of people around my age, I'm going to turn 33 in a couple months, give up altogether, because they just haven't seen the sustainable growth they need to feel good in their careers or their writing lives.

Danielle: Then what excites you about writing or about teaching? What keeps you motivated?

Aram: Staying organized helps. Teaching, for me, seems high stakes. Every time I step into a classroom, I worry about what impact I'm having on my students. Writing, over the years, has become more low stakes. I think when I was starting out in my early 20s, I was really worried about things like, when am I going to get a book published? When am I going to win XYZ awards? Am I going to get these publications and do all this stuff? I stopped thinking like that. I don't think I think about the writing anymore in terms of what it's going to give me in the long term. I think about it in terms of what it's doing for me personally, emotionally or intellectually. Not financially or professionally.

Danielle: Are there any final takeaways that you have for your students or future writers? Better yet, is there anything you want to say to people who haven't been in your classroom?

Aram: Just know that, there's no right formula to sustain yourself as an artist. Don't constantly worry about what your peers are doing or define yourself by these kinds of arbitrary barriers or signs of progression. Learn to say no and enjoy what you write. Ask a lot of questions and always interrogate what you're doing. That will result in growth. I think that's really the biggest takeaway, don't be in a rush. Do what you need to do for you before doing what you think you need to do as an artist. It's more important for you to have a sense of self and happiness over superficial accomplishment as a writer. That's going to go away really fast.



THE PORTRAIT

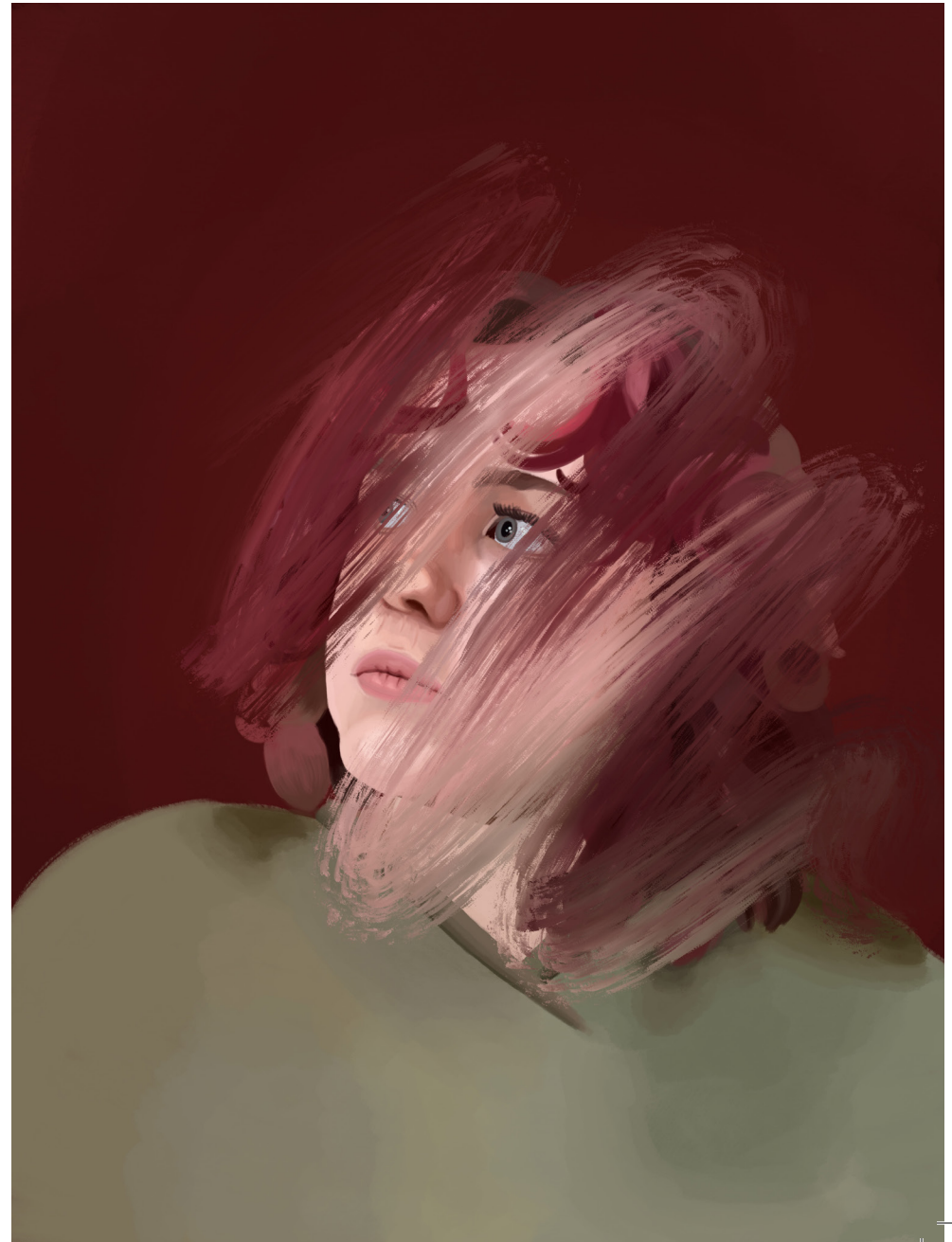
Sarah Potwin

Oil on Toned Canvas

SELF PORTRAIT

Sage Warner

Digital Art



EXPANSE

Abigail Thompson

These bones are old (older than the cracked pavement under my feet, older than the pile of ashes in the fire pit, older than the green boughs that stretch above my head) and I am merely a passing tenant. Taking them on an adventure across a world they have never seen as pay for my visit.

Rings adorn my fingers with the strength of brass knuckles (giving me a confidence I used to hope to learn). I stoke the coals that smolder behind my glare with the fire iron gripped in my mind's eye. I am not unbroken, but I have gathered my pieces (and glue shines gold between the mended gaps).

The days are short now (though the sun shines well into the night), and my waking hours are full once more. Dreams fill my vision, conversation streams from my fingertips, and stories are woven in my mind (words and sounds tangling together into worlds I catch glimpses of). The heat that covers my shoulders is less oppressive now (the cold rises to meet it and I feel them mingle on my skin).

Time bends my bones and tightens my tendons (I feel myself becoming *more* with each passing day) and I ask myself, at what time will I wash out into this deep blue sea? Reaching my hands up to the sky as if to gather the stars in my fists (only to scatter them again like grains of sand into the surf). Sleep calls to my mind, but I keep my eyes open.

I am but stardust, molded anew each night and baked into clay by the morning sun rising in the east. I am a person that sees Earth for its stars and the universe in the people who surround me; a person that a younger version of me would not recognize (and I think it is good that she couldn't, for she is me and she continues to live inside me and she reminds me of how far I have come). I exist, and that is enough (living in pools of moonlight and the pause between my breaths). I am the universe realizing itself (again and again), a lifetime of discovery through new eyes.

SINGER 600E SERIES

Victoria Schultz

Singer 600E Series

Sitting in Nana's office listening
to the rhythmic hum, like an angry bee.
Interested in the lost art, Nana
insisted teaching me as Baba did.

Cord frayed, propped up by three books to send
needed power to the jumping metal.
Light bulb broken, the sun illuminates
the satin trapped in the machinery.

Manipulating the fabric through the
feed dogs, constantly turning the handwheel
to stop the inevitable stalling,
produced a steady path behind the foot.

The trail of stitches, passed down from mother
to daughter, five generations sat here.

YOUTHFUL POOL

Malia Wisham

50 years ago, your windows glistened with sunlight,
misty rays cascading a prism of color,
contributing life as sunlit glares reflect for 25 yards in
your pure blue glassy water.

Gentle waves oscillating a lifeless body,
twisting the magnificent glare into a malevolent grimace,
oxygen caressing deceased lips as mocking laughter,
uncapable of purging your smooth water from expired lungs,
sinking

12 feet

deep,

suffocating

in darkness.

The light clouding an image,
drowning in full luminosity,

without

notice.

Now you sit decrepit
windows, shattered, enclosed
as if padded away in an asylum,
to protect people from yourself.

Deprived of cheerful rays,
your remnants of dark green foggy water,
chlorinated with feverish suffocating,
golden rust, aged as water

rips apart your remains

Chipping away your colored tiles,
leaving exposed your sharp rigid edges,
the laughter of happiness,
haunting your walls.



THE RAVINE

Emelie-Emric Pennington-Davis

We take sweaty refuge beneath a tangle of douglas fir and sun-crisped dogwood. Down here, the air tastes like God put the idea of summer into a cosmic juicer and squeezed hard. It's ambrosia, swimming with heat like pulp.

You stoop to shake the silty dust from your sandals. That oversized straw hat flops low over your eyes, shadowing even the eternally-amused upward flick of your mouth. I ask inanely if you're ok. You chuckle and tell me you're quite well.

But still, wild blackberry thorns hook in just under my skin. I'm not afraid you won't follow me down this brushy trail; instead, I fear that you'd do it because I asked you to. I want you to want this not because of me but instead with me.

"It's hotter down here than it used to be. Fucking climate change." I scrub my sweat-salted nose into the collar of my tee, incompetently inviting you to suggest we turn around.

You grin and sway your hips ever so slightly. Your old metal water bottle, still scabbily sporting those hibiscus decals you got years before I knew you, sloshes sonorously against the lovely topographical swell of your pelvic bone.

I laugh and I breathe in trail-dust and apprehension.

"I came prepared, darling. Now let's go see this creek."

We have not dropped hands since we left my house but I squeeze gently, just to feel the fragile, sticky grip of your hand pulse back to me.

The path tips and switches down the hill, a methodical wandering that leads us ever more easterly, evermore down. Beneath the summer-hum of insects, you could almost miss the watery breath of a creek. I worry, unreasonably, that you won't believe it to be here.

The amber heat is worse than ever; it's too hot to turn and kiss, too quiet to talk. The bottle at your hip clunks hollowly, and when I glance back, the golden peach-curve of your chin slides with sweat.

We walk. I regret what I ask of you.

It's then I see the moss. It is deep, cold green, curls wet even in the July air. And suddenly we're there. We've found where the sides of the hills meet, the press of two palms. Here, the last of the cool air has fallen to rest, like ribs retracting beneath an exhale. The stream is narrow and quick and palest blue, shifting skin showing the vein below. Soft blurring curves of dark rock slope into shadowed sand; I think I see a fish, a trout maybe, iridesce away from our eyes.

You don't gasp or smile, but you raise your head, your eyes brown as wet dirt, speckled darker like scales or shadows. You look not to me but the creek and, finally, I breathe in cool air. You let go of my hand and your fingers dip, like pale drinking roots, beneath the water.

STRINGS

Nathan Lovitt

When Harold laid down on the cold silver table a surgeon
stood behind him and cut away at his skull,
pulling back flaps of hair, skin,
and bone.

The doctor looked inside Harold's head
and saw a criss-crossed mesh of strings,
like a ball of rubber bands stretched out
over an embroidery frame.

Gingerly he reached inside
with tiny metal tweezers,
sterile and precise,
and plucked a string.

The string vibrated with the sound of memory,
of the glow of stalks of wheat under golden midday sun.

The surgeon plucked more, and soon
the operating room was alive
with a melody of Harold's life,

a song of rain spilling out of gutters clogged with leaves.
A crescendo of the bristling red face of an angry old man.
Verses of the smell of a new station wagon, the bronze key
to a house.
Gentle harmonies of the soft whisper of a lover.

Then the surgeon happened upon a frayed string,
its note discordantly playing to the tune of tears,
of a child saying goodbye through body-heaving sobs
while hanging out the window of a small car.

Mercifully the surgeon reached inside and pulled on the string,
unspooling more with it, muting the once vibrant songs
of days spent playing with pastel blue chalk on the sidewalk
and a lawn sprinkler spraying prism-like droplets into the air.

Silenced was the sweet sound of the child's innocent voice,
but so was the rasp of their cries and broken chords of their
flushed, tear-streaked cheeks, red and wet like the dew-covered
apples they used to pick from the tree in the small backyard.

When Harold was stitched back together and sent on his way,
he could no longer hear the music. There was only the faint warble
of small, angular swallows as they flew up and around, flitting
between the trees outside his empty home.

CONTRIBUTORS

Marlee Lawson is a first-year PLU student from Olympia, Washington. Her favorite art mediums are watercolor and gouache, and her works are mostly inspired by nature and sentimental imagery from her life.

Sage Warner is a history and religion double major with a minor in critical race studies. In general, they care about and enjoy too many things than what is reasonable considering they are always busy. Sage's favorite season is spring, and they will often take very long walks under the pretense of going somewhere just to get outside.

Emily Toycen is an Environmental Studies and Hispanic Studies double major with a minor in English Literature and will be graduating from PLU this Spring. She is an avid outdoorswoman and loves to write poetry about her experiences with nature. After school, Emily plans to continue working in the outdoor industry and writing along the way.

Victoria Schultz is a second-year Creative Writing student and is thrilled to share her work through Saxifrage. In her free time, she likes to read, hike and sew. She would like to dedicate this piece to her grandmother, who taught her the art of sewing.

Sarah Potwin is a Senior Graphic Design major as well as a member of the PLU softball team. Her interest in art was sparked by her grandmother & PLU alum Karen Holt at the age of 5 when she taught her how to use watercolors at the dining room table. As an artist she hopes to inspire others to dip their toe into the art world, and to showcase that art and inspiration exist everywhere.

Emelie-Emric Pennington-Davis (She/He/They) is a senior with an English and Psychology double major and a new Studio Art minor. He loves all things strange and creative; when she's not embroidering, playing Dungeons and Dragons or writing rambling queer poetry, they're off wandering the woods, looking for bones and fungi.

Elizabeth Bankowski is an Art Major at PLU with a concentration in oil painting. She has an interest in painting portraits as well as the human figure. Elizabeth tends to paint portraits from old family photos because it has personal significance.

Malia Wisham is a Biology major and Literature minor. She likes to merge science and literature to create one eloquent homogenous mixture. She enjoys the creativity and freedom of poetry, and finds meaning in using personification to view locations (pools) in a new light. She loves swimming.

Rachel Mouer is a 19-year-old student and artist currently living on campus at PLU, and Memory/Creation is a comic inspired by her J-term class, Contemporary Narratives of the Armenian Genocide. Rachel is an eclectic creator who loves picking up different mediums and has worked on projects ranging from cute plushies to decorative fire hydrants. You can usually find her drawing bunnies, skating, or being bad at video games.

PJ Sills is a first-year student here at PLU and an aspiring high school English teacher. Sills is 22 years old, and his favorite part about the degree he is pursuing is being able to develop poetry and creative writing. Some of Sills' favorite ways to spend his time are with friends, making art of any kind, going on drives, and curating playlists. Sills also likes to climb mountains every now and then.

Abigail Thompson (she/they) is a second-year anthropology major with a passion for writing and vocal music. They can usually be found wearing a flannel and too much jewelry while vibing to some song on spotify.

Nathan Lovitt is a senior English Writing major and aspiring poet from Tacoma, Washington. He loves blurring the lines between the mundane and the fantastical, and when he isn't writing he spends his time building sets for community theatre productions.

Milagros Garcia is a first-year transfer student with a major in Art and Design. She mainly focuses on painting and photography but is exploring different art mediums during her time at PLU. When she's not in Ingram Hall working on projects she enjoys spending time outdoors with friends, bingeing movies, and driving to new places!

Anna Nguyen is a writer from Tennessee who is currently studying English Literature and French. Their poetry and short stories have appeared in Oyster River Pages and Saxifrage.

Abbie Hughes is a first-year student majoring in Strategic Communication and minoring in English Writing and Anthropology. When she is not reading for her IHON classes or playing the alto saxophone, she is kept sane by her friends. Abbie can be spotted snuggling up in a blanket watching Paddington 2 on the weekends.

Mila Fuentes is a Film & Media Studies major from Portland, OR who hopes to be a screenwriter. This is her first time sharing her stories publicly, and she hopes you enjoy them.

Stephanie Knaack is a senior at PLU, working towards a BA in psychology and a minor in writing. Besides writing, she enjoys reading, watching horror movies, and hanging out with her cat, Goose.

EDITORIAL TEAM

Casey Brown is a fourth year pursuing a Bachelor of Arts in English Writing and a minor in Communications. She is currently completing her senior capstone in poetry writing. This is her 2nd year in Saxifrage and has enjoyed every moment of it. When she is not participating in school related activities, she's watching reality TV or curating dozens of playlists for her favorite music.

Lisa Ha is a second year Computer Science and Design student, and an aspiring creator and storyteller. She dreams of art she later makes and ultimately hopes to help construct a more equitable future through inclusive design. Outside of school, she enjoys reading, crocheting, making comics, and painting.

Ally Lessard is a fourth year Environmental Studies and English Writing and double major. When not writing, she can be found listening to music, spending time outside, or probably working, unfortunately. This is her second year as an editor, and she hopes you enjoy the stories found inside.

Danielle Pernell is a fourth year Creative Writing major and Publishing minor. She is a romance reader and currently working on her first queer romance novel set to come out September of this year. When she is not obsessively writing, she can be found making playlist for the characters that live in her head or researching queer history.

Emily Powell is a fourth year Creative Writing student with minors in Norwegian and Communications. When she's not writing, she's playing Dungeons & Dragons with her roommates, riding her horse by the river, and watching far too many superhero cartoons.

John Englehardt is a Visiting Assistant Professor at PLU, and the lead mentor for Saxifrage. His first novel, *Bloomland*, won the Dzanc Books Prize for Fiction, the VCU Cabell First Novelist Award, and was named a book of the year by Kirkus Reviews and Electric Literature. He has previously taught writing classes at Seattle University, Hugo House, and University of Arkansas.



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